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An essay on the religion of the Bambara

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The loincloth of a woman who has given birth to twins is made of the sukaba band with large, regular, alternating squares of yellow and indigo. The mother places on the garment as an offering a little of the millet mash she feeds her children for the first time.

291
Normal Garb

531
Decorative Art

773
Mythology

The band nyoronga was formerly used for shrouds. The king would wear a whole garment of this or had three bands sewn onto his tunic when he went off to war; thus he wore his own shroud. A brave man would tie a piece of it to the barrel of his rifle to show his indifference in the face of death. A strip was tied to the right hand of those killed on the battlefield as a reward for having done their duty. Today, a shred of this band is hung at the door of a home where a death has occurred; People bandage a wounded limb with it before going to the healer's.

291
Normal Garb

531
Decorative Art

773
Mythology

The wutu tyerokole with three stripes is worn by a child born after the death in infancy of numerous brothers and sisters. It represents the departure of these members of the family and their return in the newborn. Shaking such a band in the air honors the seventh sky and the seventh earth and asks their protection for the child. This cloth is never worn at funerals.

291
Normal Garb

531
Decorative Art

773
Mythology

The kemba (literally, mother of scarifications) (Pl. III, a, 10) substitutes for scarifications when it has not been possible to perform them; on the other hand, this band is taboo to those who are ritually scarred.

291
Normal Garb

531
Decorative Art

773
Mythology

The warabawolo (Pl. III, a, 12) represents the lion of the Diara: the first son of this family was born on this cloth. A boy born with a lock of hair on his forehead is seated on the cotton band to make him strong and rich. Formerly the king made a rug for his throne out of it. Since the lion is their taboo, the Diara do not have the right to wear it or even to see it.

291
Normal Garb

531
Decorative Art

773
Mythology

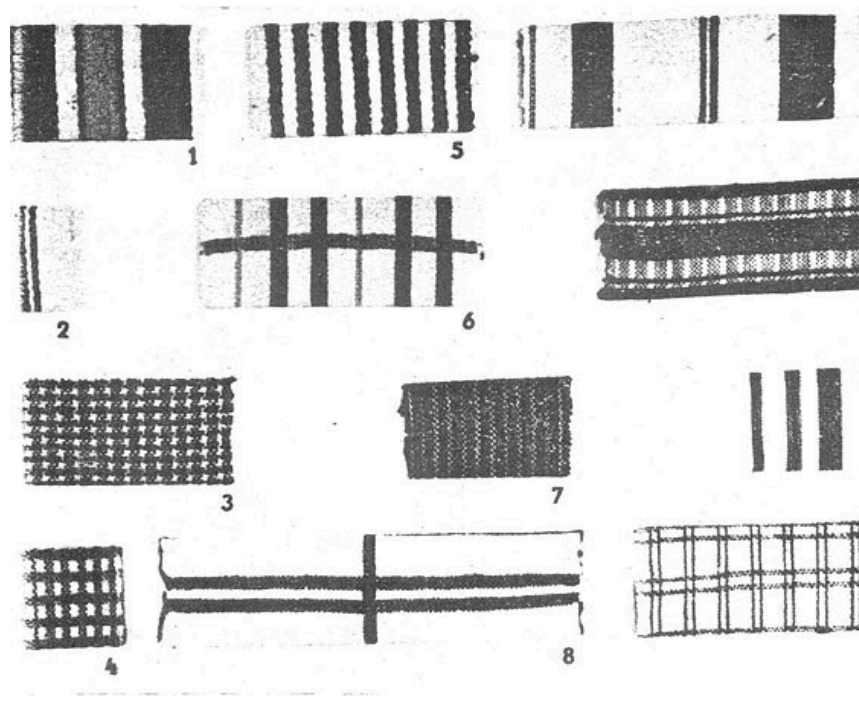
Weapons and Tools

Originally, men lived by hunting and fishing. But hunger drove them to eat plants of which the first three are the yayal̃e, an aquatic plant commonly found on the shores of the Niger; the narakata, couch grass; and the norolā size, commonly called cramcram (1). Long ■ 153a

262
Diet

291
Normal Garb

(a) Bands of cotton (the warp is presented vertically).



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Plate III

(b) Offering of a band of cotton to the dasiri tree (Soroba).



(a) Pot dipping after firing (Konodimini).



Plate IV

(b) Communal anvil, kula, of the blacksmiths (Konodimini).



154 before the cultivation of cotton and cereals was known to them, the Bambara worked the soil with wooden sticks around the base of those grasses whose seeds they then sowed. As their stock of tools developed, they began to make the first hoes and axes. In the case of the Mandé Bambara (2) the origin of these tools is linked with the history of the blacksmiths, numu, who form a kind of caste in this part of Africa as in many others. They practice endogamy, maintain joking relationships, senankuya, with other Blacks, and are in charge of certain cults dedicated to ancestors and to Faro (3).

1. These three plants are respectively: Andropogon (Hyparrhenia) hirtus, Digitaria debilis, Cenchrus catharticus.

2. The names and the origin of tools of the **Bambara** of the Ségou region are different.

3. On the myth of the divine origin of blacksmiths, see S. de Ganay, "Notes sur la théodicée **bambara**." See also infra, p. 53 n. 1

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